WEEK 6 · LECTURE L2 · UNITS I AND II

Reading Pulse Data Honestly

Driver analysis and its traps, five errors in reading a pulse survey, and how to tell a real change from noise.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain what a key driver chart shows and what it does not.
- Identify five common errors in interpreting survey change.
- Distinguish percentage points from percent change.
- Critique a dashboard for what it hides.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 4 (analyze engagement data and interpret survey results).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Engagement rose by 0.2 after our intervention, so the intervention worked.

List three other explanations before accepting it.

THEORY IN DEPTH · JOHNSON AND LEBRETON (2004)

What a driver chart really shows

THE CORE IDEA

Key driver analysis regresses engagement on item scores and calls the largest weights drivers.

HOW IT WORKS

When predictors are correlated, they split their weight unpredictably; relative importance methods are needed.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Even a correct driver is an association, not proof that changing it changes engagement.

IN PRACTICE

Pay and recognition items correlate; a chart ranks pay first one year and recognition first the next.

EXAM LENS

Use it to critique dashboards. A driver is a hypothesis to test, not a finding to act on blindly.

FIVE ERRORS IN READING A PULSE

Why a change may not be a result

Error	What happens
Regression to the mean	Units chosen because they scored worst tend to score better next time anyway
Survivorship	Those who left are no longer in the survey
Nonresponse	Who answers differs from who does not
Common method bias	One survey, one respondent: correlations are inflated
Points against percent	A favorable share rising from 20 to 25 percent is 5 points, a 25 percent relative rise

Barnett et al. (2005); Rogelberg and Stanton (2007); Podsakoff et al. (2003)

Regression to the mean

THE CORE IDEA

Extreme scores partly reflect chance, so on remeasurement they move toward the average.

HOW IT WORKS

If the worst units are picked for an intervention, they will improve even if the intervention does nothing.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

It does not mean real change is absent, only that a comparison group is needed to see it.

IN PRACTICE

Illustrative: the five lowest scoring branches rise from 3.1 to 3.4; untreated branches that also started at 3.1 rise to 3.3.

EXAM LENS

Always ask for a comparison group. The intervention adds 0.3 minus 0.2, which is 0.1, not 0.3 (illustrative figures).

THEORY IN DEPTH · PODSAKOFF ET AL. (2003)

Common method bias

THE CORE IDEA

When the same people report both cause and effect on one survey, correlations are inflated.

HOW IT WORKS

Mood, consistency motives and item wording push answers in the same direction.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Statistical remedies help but cannot fully remove the bias; design remedies are better.

IN PRACTICE

A survey finds manager support "drives" engagement, but both were rated by the same employee on the same day.

EXAM LENS

Recommend separating sources or time points. This earns critical analysis marks in data questions.

DASHBOARD THEATRE

When the display replaces the decision

SYMPTOMS

Many colors, no comparison group, no confidence interval, no owner for action.

SURVEY FATIGUE · ROGELBERG AND STANTON (2007)

Frequent surveys without visible action lower response and trust.

THREE QUESTIONS

Compared with what? Who is missing? Which single decision should this drive?

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Engagement surveys tell leaders what to do." Critically evaluate. **20 marks**

A strong answer: explains driver analysis and its limits; covers regression to the mean, nonresponse and common method bias; proposes a sound process.

A pulse shows engagement up after a program in the lowest scoring units. Assess whether the program worked. **20 marks**

A strong answer: names rival explanations; asks for a comparison group; uses Barnett et al.; recommends a design that could show the effect.

Distinguish percentage points from percent change with an example. **10 marks**

A strong answer: correct definitions; correct arithmetic; why the difference misleads.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. A driver is an association, not a lever
2. The worst units improve anyway: always ask for a comparison group
3. Points are not percent

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

Rousseau, D. M. (1995). *Psychological contracts in organizations: Understanding written and unwritten agreements*. Sage. Introduction.

Mayer, R. C., Davis, J. H., & Schoorman, F. D. (1995). An integrative model of organizational trust. *Academy of Management Review, 20*(3), 709–734.

Schaufeli, W. B., & Bakker, A. B. (2004). Job demands, job resources, and their relationship with burnout and engagement: A multi sample study. *Journal of Organizational Behavior, 25*(3), 293–315. Reread for interpreting pulse data.

HOW TO USE THESE

These are the Week 6 set readings. Schaufeli and Bakker (2004) is the core reading for this lecture. The Lesson Plan also lists a synthesis review of Buckingham and Goodall (2015), Doerr (2018) and Cappelli and Tavis (2016); it is good revision for Unit I.

Sources for this lecture (1 of 2)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Barnett, A. G., van der Pols, J. C., & Dobson, A. J. (2005). Regression to the mean: What it is and how to deal with it. *International Journal of Epidemiology, 34*(1), 215–220. https://doi.org/10.1093/ije/dyh299

Johnson, J. W., & LeBreton, J. M. (2004). History and use of relative importance indices in organizational research. *Organizational Research Methods, 7*(3), 238–257. https://doi.org/10.1177/1094428104266510

Podsakoff, P. M., MacKenzie, S. B., Lee, J. Y., & Podsakoff, N. P. (2003). Common method biases in behavioral research: A critical review of the literature and recommended remedies. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 88*(5), 879–903. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.88.5.879

Sources for this lecture (2 of 2)

Rogelberg, S. G., & Stanton, J. M. (2007). Introduction: Understanding and dealing with organizational survey nonresponse. *Organizational Research Methods, 10*(2), 195–209. https://doi.org/10.1177/1094428106294693